

MENSTRUATION DISCRIMINATION: THE MENSTRUAL TABOO AS A RHETORICAL FUNCTION OF DISCOURSE IN THE NATIONAL AND INTERNATIONAL ADVANCES OF WOMEN'S RIGHTS

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In an American advertisement for Tampax® Pearl Tampons™ which appeared in *Cosmopolitan* in 2005, a scuba diver is pictured and appears only a few yards away from a giant shark. The caption reads, "A leak can attract unwanted attention." The message in this advertisement tells women that leaking blood is not without consequences, often dangerous and deadly. It plays upon the old tabooed message that leaks of blood can cause harm by attracting dangerous and deadly wild animals. While the belief that wild animals are attracted to menstrual blood is a proven myth, a particular modern truth remains implicit in the advertisement: leaks can cause so much embarrassment and shame that you will feel like dying rather than engage in the social public sphere. In our modern American culture, women are encouraged to hide their menstruation by maintaining strict codes of cleanliness and concealment.

Despite advances in scientific knowledge and progressive social relations, treating menstruation as a taboo topic has remained the popular approach since ancient times. Today, the menstruation taboo remains a phenomenon in all cultures. Within Western culture, messages and campaigns exist to end international menstrual taboos and encourage women's advancement through access to the public sphere. However the discourses contain messages which continue to portray

menstruation as an act that threatens to publicly harm women and expose their weakness. This study explores the recent dissemination of such conflicting messages to the global community. I contend that modern political and consumer campaigns construct public arguments about values such as women's rights and equal citizenship through a discourse of menstruation taboo that restricts and limits improvements for women in the public sphere.

I begin the analysis by showing how the menstruation taboo operates as a rhetorical strategy to construct identity and division. I trace the history of women's advancement, the changing nature of the menstruation taboo and its influence in allowing Western women to access the public sphere on the basis that they guard against bodily pollution. Finally, I examine the complex nature of today's "menstruation politics" by arguing that state and consumer campaigns, such as Procter & Gamble's "Protecting Futures" campaign and the integration of female interrogators in the War on Terror, appear to initiate "discourses of equality" with the purpose of advancing women, while simultaneously reifying rhetoric that risks marginalizing menstruating women in the public sphere.

The Role of Taboo (A Rhetorical Function of Discourse)

Anthropologist, Mary Douglas (2004), defined taboo as:

[A] spontaneous coding practice which sets up a vocabulary of spatial limits and physical and verbal signals to hedge around vulnerable relations. It threatens specific dangers if the code is not respected. Some of the dangers which follow on taboo-breaking spread harm indiscriminately on contact. Feared contagion extends the danger of a broken taboo to the whole community. (p. xiii)

According to Douglas, communities maintain order by recognizing a taboo and obeying its avoidance rules. Douglas argues that societies code elements as taboo, dirty, or dangerous in order to protect distinctive categories of their universe and to distinguish the ambiguous and the sacred. As such, taboos are often created by

“leaders of the society” and “controllers of opinion” to structure social relations and stabilize power structures (Douglas, p. xiii). Early cultures created taboos around such elements as pollution produced by the body, just as members of modern societies categorize the unclassifiable as “dirty” or “dangerous” in order to establish a social structure and justify behavior. Thus, categorization of dirt and the customs surrounding such elements continues a tradition of using “rituals of purity and impurity” to “create unity in experience” (Douglas, p. 3).

For Douglas, the rituals that create a shared experience both among and within communities organize reality. Members of a society are required to take seriously that society’s rituals and taboos because they operate as arguments and “truths” which construct a culture’s way of knowing. Members of a culture may not entirely understand why the avoidance of a particular pollutant, food, or touch “eliminates” the danger or risk, but they accept such claims and corresponding rituals as necessary because it is a part of their world. In this context dirt represents disorder. Through rituals, cultures tame dirt, reject it, or use it in creative ways so that order reemerges in the culture. Rituals of cleanliness and hygiene reflect the social relations in the culture, commonly subordinating a group of people on the basis of physical differences described as body pollution. For example, taboos have been used to reinforce gender hierarchies. These taboos function as social arguments compelling social adherence in regards to gender relations. Douglas states, “There are beliefs that each sex is a danger to the other through contact with sexual fluids. According to other beliefs, only one sex is endangered by contact with the other, usually males from females, but sometimes the reverse. Such patterns of sexual danger can be seen to express symmetry or hierarchy” (p. 4). Douglas explains that sexual pollution and bodily pollution are understood as symbols which represent the relations between parts of society and mirror hierarchy. For Douglas, a resemblance or association exists between the body’s physical boundaries and danger in a community. Thus, rituals controlling bodily pollution allow a society to understand their society and its boundaries.

Douglas' explanation of this function of taboo mirrors Kenneth Burke's explanation of how humans use symbols, rituals and ceremonies to construct identity (1966). As the "symbol using animal," humans mark the behavior and orientation of others to develop their own sense of self (Burke, p. 3). In other words, people use symbols rhetorically to organize, argue and create understanding between others and ourselves, or to create opposing identities. Burke explains, "Identification is affirmed with earnestness precisely because there is division. Identification is compensatory to division. If men were not apart from one another, there would be no need for the rhetorician to proclaim their unity" (1969b, p. 22).

According to Burke, one does not need to sharply scrutinize "identification" to find its ironic counterpart, division (1969b, p. 23). Through this theory of identification, Burke provides an explanation for how taboo operates in rhetorical terms. Taboo is society's ritual for crafting identity through the process of demarcating differences in discourses. Taboo seeks to expose the arguments, beliefs and/or behaviors that construct an "us" and a "them." According to this explanation, taboo, such as the menstruation taboo, is used to create divisions between or common identification among groups of people. In the case of the menstruation taboo, a division is constructed between men and women, and this division becomes one way we identify, mark, argue and/or justify sexual difference.

In *The Philosophy of Literary Form*, Burke (1969) explains the processes of proclaiming and embracing an identity. One method for engaging in reidentification involves the process of scapegoating. He states: "Since the symbolic transformation involves a sloughing off, you may expect to find some variant of killing in the work . . . So we get to the 'scapegoat,' the 'representative' or 'vessel' of certain unwanted evils, the sacrificial animal upon whose back the burden of these evils is ritualistically loaded" (Burke, 1969a, p. 40). As societies grew in social complexity, sacrificial animals were replaced by other humans who were made "worthy" of sacrifice. Burke describes one

strategy of scapegoating: the creature becomes worthy of sacrifice fatalistically due to a personal flaw or a punishable action.

The ritual of scapegoating becomes a form of symbolic redemption—a strategy necessary to keep order. Burke explains the motive and impulse to keep society's "symmetry," a strategy to keep order:

In their societies, they will seek to keep order. If order, then a need to repress the tendencies to disorder. If repression, then responsibility for imposing, accepting, or resisting the repression. If responsibility, then guilt. If guilt, then the need for redemption, which involves sacrifice, which in turn allows for substitution. At this point, the logic of perfection enters. (1961, p. 314)

According to Burke, most religious stories are illustrations of the guilt-redemption cycle that becomes a template for all other stories. Burke explains: "Though this may be a mystery theologically, its logological analogue is not mysterious. Logologically, there is a 'fall' from a prior state of unity, whenever some one term is broken into two or more terms, so that we have the 'divisiveness' of 'classification' where we formerly had had a 'vision of perfect oneness'" (Burke, 1961, p. 175).

An example commonly invoked by Burke is the story of Adam and Eve and their fall from the Garden of Eden. Burke's cycle begins with a sense of uncertainty or disruption which becomes linked to contamination or pollution. Once Adam and Eve ate the apple from the Tree of Knowledge, they were no longer "pure"; thus they were labeled polluted and removed from the Garden. When order cannot be kept, then the individual experiences guilt, and shortly thereafter seeks redemption. Burke explains that redemption can be achieved through two courses, mortification (or self sacrifice) or the identification of a scapegoat (someone to blame), such as Adam and Eve. In order for us to end guilt and begin redemption, Burke contends that we are motivated to participate in symbolic redemptive acts that we identify with the sin. For women, menses becomes the source of this feeling and evidence of difference. The menstruation taboo not only demarcates women from men, but also makes women feel guilt. By

participating in rituals of cleanliness and following normative paths to absolution, they acknowledge their complicity in the guilt redemption cycle and their agreement with the claim that the bodily act is pollution.

Through Burke we learn the rhetorical significance of society's scapegoats. Since we have no identity without difference and since the existence of difference requires the presence of a scapegoat, all societies require a scapegoat to justify their unified identity. In his essay, "The Rhetoric of Hitler's Battle," Burke explains:

People so dislike the idea of internal division that, where there is a real internal division, their dislike can easily be turned against the man or group who would so much as name it, let alone proposing to act upon it. Their natural and justified resentment against internal division itself, is turned against the diagnostician who states it as a fact. This diagnostician, it is felt, is the cause of the disunity he named. (1969a, p. 206)

Burke maintains that society fears losing its unity and identity and as a result finds ways to rhetorically demarcate difference. By finding scapegoats or enforcing feelings of mortification onto others we reestablish order and identification in our society. Thus, menstruating women experience more than their biological menstrual cycle; every month they experience the guilt-redemption cycle, which society has come to recognize as the menstrual taboo. Women understand the implied social argument whereby their participation authenticates the social contract to engage in purity rituals.

Douglas and Burke show that division is critical in constructing identity for others; thus, taboo is one discursive strategy used by societies in order to create division. Douglas and Burke demonstrate the conditions of possibility that allows the discursive establishment of societal taboos. By understanding the motives that craft a society's discourse and the argument for division we can identify rhetorical and argumentative strategies that propagate taboos and their meanings and attempt to alter divisive discourse to end discriminatory practices. Through a

rhetorical and argumentative lens, the current state of the Western menstruation taboo and its dissemination of messages is exposed to show how discrimination toward women continues in Western and non-Western cultures. The continued existence of the menstruation taboo may be used as a justification to bar women from accessing the entirety of the public sphere.

Gendered Citizenship and the Western Menstrual Taboo

It has been established by such scholars as Jürgen Habermas, John Dewey and Hannah Arendt that access to the public sphere is equated to rights of citizenship. For example, Habermas' 1962 work, *Structural Transformations of the Public Sphere*, traces the development of the bourgeois public and private spheres and describes members of the public similarly to traditional notions of the Western "citizen." The public sphere consists of a group of middle class, educated citizens, who engage in rational-critical argumentation in salons, coffee houses, and "table" and literary societies throughout Europe (Habermas p. 32-34). Habermas explains:

The bourgeois public sphere may be conceived above all as the sphere of private people come together as a public; they soon claimed the public sphere regulated from above against the public authorities themselves, to engage them in a debate over the general rules governing relations in the basically privatized by publicly relevant sphere of commodity exchange and social labor. (p. 27)

For Habermas, the bourgeois public sphere became an idealized prototype for the foundation of pure democracy and citizenship by governing through societal consensus. The existence of a public sphere allowed for a private sphere to emerge and provided an intimate sphere or familial sphere, thus reserving the public sphere for the citizenry's government and rational-critical discourse.

Since the members of Habermas' public gain access to the public sphere by owning property and acting as a sovereign leader of a household, the Western citizen was conflated with "private man" for, during this time, men were solely the "owner of

commodities” and “head of the family.” Throughout the centuries, women were constructed as non-citizens because of exclusion from the public sphere premised on women’s sexuality and their association with the body. Ruth Lister (2002) illustrates that, given an explicit connection between the public sphere and citizenship exists, the public sphere contains a gendered divide that affects citizens and sexual minorities. She states:

The male heterosexual human or citizen is firmly located in the public sphere, disassociated from the female private sphere, or the realm of necessity and the body. Indeed, public space has been described as ‘male, heterosexual.’ This public-private divide represents the very foundation stone as traditionally conceived and practiced. As such, it has both privileged male heterosexual access to the public sphere of citizenship and regulated the terms on which heterosexual women and lesbians and gays have been able to enter the public sphere as citizens. (194-195)

According to Lister, traditional notions of citizenship are “disembodied” since political participation was linked to masculine notions of reason and rationality (p. 193). Thus, women were initially denied citizenship in most Western cultures because society accepted the arguments that they were more emotional and passionate than men due to their essential nature. Lister states: “Only male individuals were deemed capable of transcending the body; women as sexual beings and as bearers of children were not” (p. 194).

Women’s association with the corporeal is relevant to another construction of Western women’s bodies as “dirty” and “leaky”. In *Volatile Bodies: Toward a Corporeal Feminism*, Elizabeth Grosz (1994) contends that certain bodily zones and bodily development have come to mark the way in which men and women in Western societies “signify, live, and practice their sexualities and desires” (p. 198). These characteristics serve to emphasize the difference between men and women and justify social arguments for male dominance, yet such cultural marks are often biologically arbitrary. Physical development marks

womanhood rather than reason and rationality. It also confines a woman to her body. Grosz explains that the measurement of womanhood is identified with the development of breasts, hips, and the onset of menstruation. She states: “While clearly the development of these characteristics leads to many different attitudes and responses . . . there remains a broadly common coding of the female body as a body which leaks, which bleeds, which is at the mercy of hormonal and reproductive functions” (Grosz, p. 204). Specifically, Grosz shows how the West constructs the female body so that it is viewed as “leaking, uncontrollable, seeping liquid . . .” (Grosz, p. 203). Grosz illustrates how our views of bodily fluids, like menstruation, are not constituted with ontological meaning, but rather are attributed meaning based on the hierarchical structuring of heterosexual male desire. She states:

[F]or the girl, menstruation, associated as it is with blood, with injury and the wound, with a mess that does not dry invisibly, that leaks, uncontrollable, not in sleep, in dreams, but whenever it occurs, indicates the beginning of an out-of-control status that she was led to believe ends with childhood. The idea of soiling oneself, of dirt, of the very dirt produced by the body itself, staining the subject, is a “normal” condition of infancy, but in the case of the maturing woman it is a mark or stain of her future status, the impulsion into a future of a past that she thought she left behind. This necessarily marks womanhood, whatever else it may mean for a particular woman, as outside herself, outside its time . . . and place . . . and thus a paradoxical entity, on the very border between infancy and adulthood, nature and culture, subject and object, rational being and irrational animal. (Grosz, p. 205)

The arguments that women are “leaky” and therefore considered emotional, natural, and irrational led to the pathology of menstruation and a *societal menstrual taboo*. This taboo allowed American society to restrict women’s rights to equality and citizenship. Historical accounts of society’s attitudes toward menstruation reveal that discourse about menses was first relegated

to the private sphere prior to the twentieth century. Like the discourse of human sexuality, women and men viewed discussions about menstruation and women's personal hygiene as unacceptable in the public. Additionally, before the invention of the sanitary napkin, women themselves were restricted to the private sphere due to menstruation. In her article, "'The Greatest Invention of the Century': Menstruation in visual and material culture," Alia Al-Khalidi (2000) explains that "the onset of menstruation marked the beginning of a different and more limited existence for Victorian girls, because 'simply to manage the hygiene of menstruation in a household where it could not be acknowledged or revealed created a sense of anxiety or shame'" (Al-Khalidi, p. 67). Management and hygiene limited women's existence because it restricted their education and communication to the woman's home. Furthermore, the secrecy and etiquette surrounding menstruation meant that communication within the home and private sphere was also carefully negotiated and regulated.

Historical archives indicate that menstruation was banished to the private and domestic spheres due to the perspective that such discussions are not pertinent to the "common good." Such silencing created an environment that hurt women by denying them proper education on the topic, relation to other women, and equal rights in the public sphere. By extension, ritualistic practices, exclusion, and commodification associated with the hiding of menstruation led to additional oppression of women.

Over time, the Western menstruation taboo's enunciative functions have changed in order to accommodate shifting historical contexts and developments. For instance, the emergence of the feminine hygiene industry and new paradigms and knowledge in the scientific community necessitated a realignment and shift in the discourse and implications of the menstruation taboo. I suggest that a modified menstrual taboo discourse was necessary to regulate and control woman's bodies ironically in a time when American society was beginning to award women additional rights. As women gained access to the public sphere, the feminine hygiene industry developed and scientific advances were made, increasing

medical knowledge about women's bodies. Nonetheless, the menstruation taboo gained a public presence to remind women that menstruation was an ongoing threat to their social status.

During the late nineteenth century and the early twentieth century, women began to access the public sphere, campaigning for the abolition of slavery and creating a suffrage movement that eventually led to the passage of the Nineteenth Amendment in 1920. Meanwhile, significant advances were made in medical knowledge and professional texts, especially in the understanding of menstruation. According to Gigi Santow (2001), although the science of menstruation remained "baffling and unexplainable" throughout the eighteenth century, "the nineteenth century, especially toward its end, was characterized by remarkable progress . . . Embryology made great advances and physiology some . . . Thereafter, operative successes 'slowly guided the profession into surgical channels, and were largely responsible for the new specialty – gynecology'" (Santow, p. 65). Since scientific advancement disproved the logic behind previous and more radical taboos, society needed to find means to keep the abject—in this case menstrual blood—outside the public sphere.

Regulatory and essentialist discourse that attempted to keep women's bodies from the public sphere slowly disappeared from medical texts; however discourse that regulated aspects of women's bodily functions was found in other elements in our culture. The rhetoric and arguments found in consumer industries, advertising, and pop culture uphold the discursive regime that reiterates the messages of the menstrual taboo.

With the addition of mass-produced feminine hygiene products, Western women were no longer limited to the private or domestic sphere during their menstrual cycle. Delaney, Lupton, and Toth (1971) explain:

The turning point seems to have come around the time women gained the vote; large percentages of the female population were gaining advanced degrees, entering the professions, and in general reaping the benefits of the 'century of struggle' for legal and political equality. An enormously liberating factor in these advances was the

mass marketing of disposable sanitary napkins after World War I. (p. 51-52)

Feminine hygiene products provide women with an easy and more effective means for concealing menstrual blood from the public. The ability to conceal menstruation made it easier for women to access jobs, careers, and education; previously menstruating women were restricted from such areas. Although the feminine hygiene industry contributed to the improvement in women's societal status, they also reinforced a menstrual taboo that emphasized fear and insecurity in order to sell products. While menstrual products are not inherently problematic, the discourse used when selling and advertising such products to women remain unnecessarily harmful and negative.

Early Western advertising campaigns illustrate the restrictions placed on the visibility of menstruation in the public sphere. During the 1880's, material culture began to control menstruation with the release of the first patent for the sanitary towel (Al-Khalidi, p. 67). The product necessitated public discourse on the hygiene of menstruating women by discussing management procedures, like the control of visibility of blood and the presence of odor or other physical signs of menstruation. Additionally, metaphorical and coded discourses about feminine hygiene products emerged to control the discussion of menstruation in the public sphere, and it also led to consumers to purchase feminine hygiene products to police their bodies and control their menstruation. Through these products and advertising campaigns, society constructed a cultural argument: women can enter the public sphere as long menstruation remains invisible and controlled. Al-Khalidi explains that the attempt to sell personal hygiene products through catalogs did not increase visibility and discussion of menstruation like a cultural critic from that time claimed; rather the discourse privatized the topic by emphasizing discreetness and attempting to limit the products' visibility in stores.

Restriction of menstruation to the private sphere continues in elements of contemporary Western society thus restricting Western women from full citizenship. According to

Elizabeth Arveda Kissling (1996), the menstrual taboo contains a communication taboo, or “the belief that menstruation should not be talked about.” Kissling explains:

Menstruation must be concealed verbally as well as physically, and communication rules and restrictions permeate and define the concealment and activity taboos. A substantial majority of American adults and adolescents believe that it is socially unacceptable to discuss menstruation, especially in mixed company. Many believe that it is unacceptable to discuss menstruation even within the family. (p. 293-294)

Al-Khalidi agrees that women’s situation today is the same: “The continuation of such strategies—emphasizing concealment and user compliance with standardized menstrual etiquette—remains evident in contemporary consumption practices” (Al-Khalidi, p. 65). Likewise, Lee and Sasser-Coen (1996) explain that information and discourse regarding menstruation are characterized by practices of discipline and concealment. Girls are introduced to this argument at an early age.

Girls are exposed to a plethora of subtle and not-so-subtle messages, whispered secretly in school playgrounds, stated matter-of-factly in lectures and documentaries, and boldly exclaimed in television commercials. Sometimes girls receive no direct personal information about menstruation at all, and occasionally they receive affirming and positive messages. (p. 61)

References to menstruation and feminine hygiene products in the mass media are also carefully regulated and limited. Carefully repressed public discourses surrounding menstruation exist only because they are necessary to privately regulate the threat of menstruation. In order to regulate women’s hygiene, hygiene products are sold and menstruation is talked about in such a way that society establishes a taboo.

Advertisements in women’s magazines and on television reveal how women are taught specific, negative associations to menstruation through arguments about its harms found in images and texts. According to Karen Houppert (1999), advertisements for

disposable pads, such as Kotex, have been full of dire warnings about preventing offensive hygiene and odors, since the products first emerged in the 1920's. "Fast-forward fifty years and Playtex plays on the same insecurities" (p. 37). The contemporary menstrual taboo constitutes a social argument to women that they are threatened by the danger of embarrassment, ostracism, or dirt caused by their own periods. According to Reirdan and Hastings (1990):

Even well educated informants have acceded to the "medicalizing" of menstruation and see menstruation and menopause as a problem to be managed, and not a natural part of a healthy women's life. In retrospect, the apparently greater openness about menstruation on the television screen, selling menstrual hygiene products and joking about PMS, perpetuate the bias of viewing menstruation as essentially a matter of hygiene and disease. (p. 20)

Societal discourse continually argues for women to feel self-conscious about menstruating. Lee and Sasser-Ceon (1996) suggest that most words used to talk about or describe female genitalia imply that it is "smelly" and "unpleasant." Because women's identities are so closely linked to their bodies, girls and women face internalized oppression, embarrassment, and shame. "In terms of gender we can say that in our society language and forms of knowledge about the female body uphold practices and justify ideas, behaviors, and policies that maintain patriarchal social relations and function symbolically to represent understandings of women's roles" (Reirdan and Hastings, p. 20).

Thus, an examination of the menstrual taboo reveals that the taboo's discourse is used to regulate and control woman's bodies and their consumption. Although women mostly entered the public sphere with the first and second waves of the feminist movement, discursive regimes allow the menstruation taboo to continue today *limiting their rights as full citizens*. Delaney, Lupton, and Toth refer to this discursive strategy as "menstrual politics." They explain:

Since the advent of modern science, the fears and prejudices surrounding menstruation have given way to an acceptance of it as a normal bodily process – at least in print. But the habits of centuries are not easily unlearned by men who depend on women’s manifest physical differences to give a rationale for their belief in her emotional, economic, and social otherness. That is why the system we call menstrual politics has by no means disappeared with the twentieth century and the ‘emancipation’ of women from their biologically determined roles. (p. 47-48)

Women are permitted access to the public sphere but they accept the argument that they must follow a strict regiment of care of the self by policing their bodies, in particular the “leak” of menstrual blood.

P&G’s Protecting Futures Campaign

While some advertisements and campaigns attempt to avoid and repress discussion of menstruation and/or the American menstrual taboo, one recent advertising campaign engaged in a very different strategy by identifying and locating origins of the taboo that are debilitating to some women. In the early months of 2008, it was nearly impossible to watch television or read a magazine without encountering advertisements for the Proctor & Gamble “Protecting Futures” campaign (2008). One particular advertisement features a desolate scene: a young, African girl in a school uniform sits alone at a wooden desk in a barren field. She appears completely isolated by her community. The advertisement displays this message in white, bold lettering: “There are lots of reasons kids miss school. Being a girl shouldn’t be one of them.” Although the purpose of the advertisement is initially unclear, further examination of the advertisement and recognition of the Always® and Tampax® logos, reveals the claim that the purchase of P&G’s feminine hygiene products will lead to the education and societal inclusion of young African girls. The advertisement explains P&G’s philanthropic campaign:

In some regions of the world, many girls have to stay home when they get their period just because they don't have protection. Which means they may fall so far behind, they drop out. You can help change that. Your purchase of Always or Tampax helps us donate 1.4 million through 2008 to the United Nations Association's HERO campaign to provide feminine protection and education to girls in Southern Africa. Because every girl deserves her chance to shine. Use your period for good at www.protectingfutures.com. (P&G, 2008)

On the surface, the campaign offers a positive and powerful message. Always® now endorses a new slogan that encourages women to “use their period for good,” which seems like a progressive move away from the contemporary taboo. Additionally, the campaign is largely viewed as an act of generosity and charity. Bree Kessler and Summer Wood (2008) describe the goals of the project:

the Protecting Futures campaign proposes to help keep young girls in school by providing schools with comprehensive support, including clean water, new classrooms, and bathrooms, year-round feeding programs, teacher training in puberty education, traveling health educators and nurses, and – of course – stockpiles of Always® pads and Tampax® tampons for a new generation of female consumers. (Kessler & Wood, p. 13)

Despite the good intentions of P&G's campaign, I agree with Kessler and Wood, who argue that the advertisements are “not-so-simple.” Although the advertisement seeks to reduce an extreme non-Western taboo, the social argument that African women are excluded from society due to menses – and for this, the campaign is to be commended – the arguments within the campaign require a critical reading in order to thoroughly understand the implications of its discourse. I contend that before we unquestioningly encourage and celebrate the appropriation of Western feminist rhetoric and the goal of social emancipation in such campaigns, critics must also consider the ways cultural and

persistent expectations of the American menstrual taboo remain intact. In other words, the “Protecting Futures” campaign criticizes the exclusion of women from public spheres, but it still uses rhetoric that reaffirms the American taboo’s stance that menstruation is debilitating and requires the disciplining and policing of female bodies. While the addition of feminine hygiene products has the ability to accommodate women in engaging in deceptive acts that hides menstruation and allows for their inclusion in society, we must remember that a hegemonic, Western perspective that stresses gender normative behavior and menstrual politics is simultaneously enforced. The “Protecting Futures” campaign signals an exigency in American society. Although the campaign attempts to address the persistence of sexual discrimination that exists throughout the world, it also indicates that the American menstrual taboo is spreading through globalization, despite the progressive and feminist rhetoric used by Western governments and corporations.

The campaign assumes that menstruation is the only obstacle to a young girl’s equal education in African countries. Kessler and Wood argue that this is a troubling claim because it is based on an assumption that menstruation is always “a debilitating, polluting phenomenon in need of control” (p. 13). Certainly, different implications and consequences derive from variations of the menstruation taboo found in all cultures and societies. Thus, it is not the case that menstruation is the same experience for every woman in every culture throughout the world. Western liberal feminism is critiqued often for generally asserting such arguments. The “Protecting Futures” campaign is problematic because it applies a similar cultural generalization too broadly to all areas of Africa. All African women do not experience exclusion with the start of menses, nor are all African women’s social status changes viewed through the lens of Western patriarchal structures. Kessler and Wood contend that, in some parts of Africa, women celebrate the start of menstruation and gain respect and status. Alma Gottlieb (1988) investigates the Beng, an ethnic group on the Ivory Coast. Gottlieb argues that although many anthropological explanations of comparative menstruation beliefs have only focused on the

polluting meaning of menstrual blood, the Beng show that menstruation is not always read as dangerous to others. “We have discovered, then, that a rule that seems to impose a restriction on women, and thus to reflect their general polluting character—the taboo on their entering the forest while menstruating—is instead part of a wider system of symbolic classification of space and fertility” (Gottlieb, p. 73). A similar rule that women should not cook for older men when menstruating is predicated on protecting fertility rather than avoiding dirt, as Beng men agree that food cooked by menstruating women is considered the most delicious food.

The “Protecting Futures” campaign also risks conflating arguments about social hierarchy in African cultures with menstruation, when a matrix of cultural beliefs is responsible for limiting the social status of women in these countries. Rarely are the cultural beliefs found in countries like Africa easily changed with consumerism of Western products. Thus, the claims made in the advertisement are dangerous generalizations that risk conflating and grouping nations, religions, cultures and populations. It also introduces Western consumer practices to cultures that may be unable to use and maintain such methods to change women’s social status.

The rhetoric of “Protecting Futures” is also troublesome because it attempts to transfer aspects of both the Western menstruation taboo and masculinized notions of Western citizenship to Africa. Strict personal hygienic rituals become a requirement for *all* women, thereby teaching African women that in order to enter into the public sphere and become a “citizen,” women should purchase and use disposable pads and consume Western images and rhetorical messages about their bodies, which are often negative. Additionally, when the West attempts to define and discursively construct women from other cultures through a Western lens, they deny culture, identity, and alternate perspectives of citizenship.

By using the “Protecting Futures” campaign, the West fails to identify, change, or solve the aspects of its own menstrual taboo; instead it reframes the taboo by drawing attention to

extreme, non-Western menstrual practices found in some foreign nations. Although the West has good intentions, Chandra Mohanty (2003) argues that such characterizations and focus on the Third World creates a paternalistic attitude toward third world women. She states:

When the category of “sexually oppressed women” is located within particular systems in the Third World that are defined on a scale that is normed through Eurocentric assumptions, not only are Third World women defined in a particular way prior to their entry into social relations, but, since no connections are made between First and Third World power shifts, the assumption is reinforced that the Third World just has not evolved to the extent that the West has. (Mohanty, p.40)

Rather than attempting to eliminate the tabooed messages in American culture, “Protecting Futures” draws attention to non-Western, radical menstrual taboos. It may provide some African women with a tool of deception to overcome culturally discriminating beliefs, like the non-Western menstrual taboo, but it leaves the notions of the Western menstruation taboo intact by persuading African women to use tampons and sanitary napkins because they, too, are “leaky” and “dirty.”

Rhetorical globalization occurs through the metaphors and concepts of “citizenship” found in the campaign’s advertisements. Through P&G’s campaign, Western notions of citizenship—such as accessing the public sphere by following masculinist hygiene norms—are reframed as pre-requisites to citizenship in all cultures. Such discursive constructions are only aspects of Western citizenship and not concepts critical to allowing oppressed members of Western society access publicly recognizable status in their countries and societies. The campaign unquestioningly assumes African women will successfully gain equal citizenship through the same means as Western women.

A rhetorical examination of P&G’s advertisement illustrates that the campaign does not create a completely inclusive environment for African girls. In fact traditional notions of the public/private spheres are reified through its rhetoric, which as I

have shown are critiqued by some feminist scholars. The discourse of the “Protecting Futures” campaign extends Western norms and expectations of citizenships to other nations and emphasizes the discursive divide between public and private spheres. In many African cultures, girls and women are clearly viewed as marginalized populations, but eliminating discrimination is more complicated than the solution provided by P&G.

I do not intend to discourage attempts to remove radical and debilitating menstruation taboos from cultures, but instead seek to show why corporations must act with caution when trying to alter cultural practices. Western women can feel accomplished knowing that some African women may experience an improved lifestyle with the introduction of P&G’s products. However, we must also accept that the solution for helping African women gain citizenship status is *not* transferring Western discursive notions of citizenship and hygienic rituals. By changing our rhetoric, we can eliminate the menstrual taboo, rather than removing one menstruation taboo only to replace it with another one.

The Use of Fake Menstrual Blood as an Interrogation Tactic in the War on Terror

Since 9/11, images of female US combatants and interrogators and liberated Muslim women are commonly found in the mass media. These images accompany a discourse of feminism and the argument that the West is advancing women’s rights throughout the world. Since the invasion of Afghanistan, the Bush Administration has portrayed the “War on Terror” and the invasion of Iraq as wars being fought for gender equality. In her article, “Keeping the Home Front Burning: Renegotiating the gender and sexuality in US mass media after September 11,” Deborah Cohler (2006) contends that the American mass media’s proliferation of photos and articles about women rights must be questioned rather than blindly accepted as a feminist agenda. These images and arguments are evidence of the emergence of the concept of “nationalist feminism.” Cohler states: “‘nationalist feminism’ highlights the dangerous thematic and rhetorical linkages between ‘progressive’ western feminists and conservative nation-builders . .

. we need to consider nationalist feminism precisely because Bush's colonial pseudo-feminism is grounded in the same historical and cultural tropes as much US liberal feminism" (p. 245). In order to further examine nationalist feminism, I critically analyze the recent appropriation of the equal rights rhetoric that justifies women's roles in the War on Terror. Although it appears that American women are progressing and gaining rights in the military, recent tasks assigned to women interrogators will potentially further propagate a Western and non-Western menstrual taboo. In particular, the use of fake menstrual blood in the interrogation of prisoners illustrates the ways in which women are used as tools in the War on Terror. Additionally, Middle Eastern women may face further oppression by their society due to the reification of the menstrual taboo. Although the government continues to fight a war justified for women's rights, interrogation tactics used to "win" the War on Terror reify both Western and non-Western social arguments that menstrual blood is threatening and dangerous, a discourse that is detrimental to women's advancement in public spheres.

During media investigations of the War on Terror, Guantanamo Bay and Abu Ghraib, reporters uncovered various interrogation techniques and strategies used by women interrogators. According to Kelly Oliver (2007), who investigates the role of female soldiers in her work *Women as Weapons of War*, columnists and writers have depicted scenarios where female interrogators place their hands down their pants and wipe fake menstrual blood across prisoners' faces. The use of female sexuality and fake menstrual blood is an attempt "to 'break' Muslim prisoners by making them unclean and therefore 'unworthy to pray'" (Oliver, p. 27). Oliver describes the reaction of army sergeant, Erik Saar, who after witnessing the invocation of menstruation, felt "unclean" and later cried in the shower. Oliver reminds readers that while Saar's disgust was directed toward the military, his horror was initiated by the spectacle of menstrual blood.

The negative reactions which result from such scenes reveal menstrual blood is feared and avoided in both Western and

non-Western cultures. Oliver agrees: "The military's use of pretend menstrual blood in interrogation makes apparent the imagined threat of menstruation in patriarchal cultures, most particularly ours. The imagined threat is made explicit when menstrual blood becomes part of the arsenal of 'sexual tactics' used by the military" (p. 28). The use of menstrual blood as an interrogation tactic has multiple implications for both American and Middle Eastern women.

First, the use of fake menstrual blood reveals the complex nature of modern menstrual politics. On the one hand, the essentialist nature of menstruation assures that Western women gain participation in the American military and the War on Terror. The exposure of fake menstrual blood and the use of one's womanhood initially ensure access to a traditionally male-dominated sphere, an action which is viewed as empowering by some women. Thus, the United States points to images of women interrogators as evidence of "progress." Fake menstruation as an interrogation tactic also allows Western women to use a symbol of bodily difference and inferiority as a means to confront discrimination in their own culture and "challenge" the tactics of terrorism. However, it is necessary to question this accomplishment by asking: what is the implication of the use of fake menstrual blood to interrogate prisoners? If access to the public requires women to hide their menstruation, what is the consequence for exposing it? I am concerned that the use of this tactic in military interrogations will serve as reminder of the biological differences that exist between men and women rather than eliminate or appropriate such disdain for menstrual blood. The consequences may further divide men and women in other areas such as the equal participation of combat and warfare. The use of women in interrogations does not signify status changes and improved rights for female soldiers; instead it turns women, their sexuality, and their biology into a weapon of war. Women's bodies are not integrated into the state; they are exploited by the state. The new role of female interrogators risks reinforcing the military's patriarchal domination and further excluding women from the

military according to the justification that female embodiment is sexual and/or dangerous.

Second, implications also exist for non-Western women in Middle Eastern cultures. For example, radical social beliefs derive from the menstruation taboo in Middle Eastern cultures, similar to the ones addressed in the “Protecting Futures” campaign. John Finer (2006), in a *Washington Post* article reports that menstruation discrimination is common throughout the Middle East. In Baghdad, July 2006, during the divorce court proceedings of Raad and Nidhal Khalil, Family Court Judge Salim al-Moussawi began his proceedings by asking Nidhal the traditional question, “Are you pure today?” By nodding her assent, the trial can continue. If Nidhal, a Shiite Muslim, was menstruating, she could not continue with court proceedings (Finer, p. A15). This example reveals that many Middle Eastern cultures maintain overt menstrual taboos. Female interrogators and the United States military exacerbate the taboo by playing on the myth that menstruation is dirty, threatening, and dangerous. The possibility always exists that prisoners and enemy combatants faced with such interrogation tactics may begin to deconstruct the taboo and accept that menstrual blood is not dangerous or powerful. However, if such an outcome was foreseen, the US would not exploit the taboo beliefs as a war tactic. Thus, the US’s exploitation of the menstrual taboo assures its reification throughout the international community and further risks discriminatory practices enacted against Middle Eastern women.

Conclusion

The “Protecting Futures” campaign and the use of fake menstrual blood as an interrogation tactic provide evidence that a “nationalist feminism” remains a dominant discourse in modern day politics. The hypocrisies of this new feminism are exposed in instances where a discursive reification of the menstrual taboo occurs. Although some discourse found in the “Protecting Futures” campaign and in the War on Terror advances women’s rights, the covert rhetorical function of the menstruation taboo threatens to harm the social status of other women. It is important that the

United States and other Western countries continue to embrace feminist ideals; however, citizens, corporations, and the US government must consider the potential setbacks in the employment of their strategies and in the appropriation of this rhetoric of equality. Recent international campaigns and governmental action indicate that, despite the scholarship of feminists and postcolonial theorists, the campaigns globally deploy a discourse of citizenship through Western constructs and ideals and risk constructing women's bodies as leaky, threatening, and exploitable. The bodies of Western and non-Western women are becoming sites of conflict for notions of Western citizenship, equal rights, and specific cultural practices.

I have argued that even when society tries to advance the rights of women, reification of the menstruation taboo has a rhetorical function to limit women's participation in other parts of the "public sphere." As the taboo is rhetorically practiced and reinforced in the United States, progressive and feminist discourses lose their potential despite the organizational and national attempts to end the menstrual taboo internationally. I have exposed the implicit ways in which an American menstrual taboo is at risk of becoming an accepted, hegemonic discourse. Identifying the discursive strategies of the taboo is the first step in challenging and ending bodily repression of women. It is imperative that communication scholars continue to identify the rhetorical and argumentative messages in international discourse, such as the American menstruation taboo, to determine whether the social results of those messages are positive or negative for women. By eliminating the rhetorical and hierarchical divisions established by social arguments and carefully considering the power of symbols like menstruation the status of women will improve in both Western and non-Western cultures.

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